COMPUTING STUDENTS –
PLACEMENT YEAR LOG REPORT

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Placement Provider & Department:	LeapGen
Workplace Supervisor Name:	Dr. Dinesh Arunathileka
Date:	30.12.2026

1. Description of activities, including projects, tasks, roles and achievements ***

I serve as a Co-Founder and the Full-Stack Developer of a four-member student startup incubated under LeapGen, the university's startup accelerator programme. Our primary venture is Yamu Car Rentals, a centralised web platform designed to connect customers with local vehicle rental companies across Sri Lanka. Before launching our software product, the LeapGen supervisory team advised us to run a practical six-week micro-business so that our team could experience real-world product preparation, physical operations, pricing, and face-to-face customer interaction. For this six-week venture, we created Desert Club, a street-side caramel pudding cart aimed at university students. Throughout this placement period, my responsibilities combined co-managing the daily operations of Desert Club and leading the end-to-end software engineering, testing, deployment, and onboarding efforts for Yamu Car Rentals.

June 2026

- Participated in structured ideation sessions with my three co-founders to select a viable concept for our six-week small business challenge. After comparing several food and student-service ideas against initial capital requirements, preparation complexity, shelf stability, and student appeal, we settled on a caramel pudding cart under the brand name Desert Club.
- Planned all operational requirements for the venture, including the physical cart design, hygienic cup packaging, ingredient sourcing, daily batch preparation schedules, and transport logistics.
- Resolved the challenge of finding a reliable cook without inflating our startup costs: one of our four team members volunteered to take charge of cooking and batch preparation, giving our team direct control over consistency and hygiene.
- Resolved the challenge of finding an affordable production kitchen: we arranged a dedicated cooking and chilling space at the home of one of our team members, eliminating external rent and allowing flexible late-evening preparation before sales days.

July 2026

Desert Club (Six-Week Small Business)

- Constructed and branded the Desert Club pudding cart and scouted high-footfall areas around state university campuses where students gather after lectures.
- Conducted multiple recipe trials to perfect our caramel pudding, adjusting caramel thickness, egg-to-milk ratios, sweetness, and setting times until the pudding held its shape reliably during transport and warm afternoon weather.
- Negotiated and obtained permission from local authorities and temple trustees to set up our stall in front of a temple near the University of Sri Jayewardenepura, launching our first physical sales point.
- Introduced the caramel pudding at an entry price of Rs. 200/- per cup during the first week to build word-of-mouth among students, and subsequently revised the price to Rs. 250/- after reviewing our unit costs for ingredients, cups, and transport alongside strong customer demand.

Yamu Car Rentals (Main Startup Venture)

- Initiated architectural planning and full-stack development for the Yamu Car Rentals web application, selecting React (with Vite) for a fast, component-driven frontend, Node.js and Express.js for the RESTful backend API, and MongoDB (via Mongoose) for flexible document data modelling.
- Evaluated and pivoted our core business model following critical guidance from Dr. Dinesh Arunathileka and the LeapGen supervisors. Our initial concept was a peer-to-peer marketplace allowing private households to rent out personal vehicles unaffiliated with commercial rental agencies. The supervisors highlighted severe operational risks in that model, including insurance coverage gaps, vehicle roadworthiness, theft liability, and customer trust. After brainstorming as a team, we pivoted to a significantly safer and more scalable B2B2C aggregator model: centralising established rental companies onto a single platform so customers can easily discover and book verified rental vehicles available in their immediate area.

August 2026

Desert Club (Six-Week Small Business)

- Expanded Desert Club operations beyond Jayewardenepura to areas surrounding the University of Moratuwa and the University of Colombo, testing customer reception across three major state university communities.
- Coordinated multi-location batch preparation, cooler transport, stock allocation, and cash handling across the four co-founders so that carts operated smoothly without running out of stock prematurely.

Yamu Car Rentals (Main Startup Venture)

- Designed and implemented the UI/UX of the Yamu Car Rentals web application, focusing on clean visual hierarchy, intuitive search filters, vehicle cards, interactive booking calendars, and a dedicated management portal for rental companies.
- Built the core full-stack modules of the platform: JWT-based authentication with role separation (customers, individual hosts, rental companies, and administrators), multi-criteria vehicle search (filtering by category, transmission, fuel type, daily rate, and location), an availability calendar that prevents overlapping date bookings, direct WhatsApp booking dispatch to connect renters with hosts immediately, and a verified customer reviews portal.
- Attended the August LeapGen training workshop on marketing strategies, applying its frameworks on target audience segmentation and value proposition messaging to our upcoming platform launch.

September 2026

- Deployed and hosted the Yamu Car Rentals web application on a live cloud environment, configuring production databases, environment variables, image uploads, and automated transactional email notifications.
- Conducted systematic functional, usability, and security testing across the hosted application to uncover edge-case bugs before onboarding external rental companies.
- Diagnosed and resolved several critical production bugs across the stack: updated rental and expiry queries so fleet rental companies could accurately view their active rentals and revenue statistics on the dashboard; fixed unpopulated company references that caused broken company profile links on vehicle cards; restricted review 'helpful' voting to authenticated users (one vote per user) to prevent guest spam; and improved error parsing for email services.
- Optimised the entire web interface—especially the Rental Company Dashboard, navigation bar, and vehicle cards—for mobile viewports, recognising that most Sri Lankan renters and fleet owners access services via smartphones.
- Launched our initial social media marketing campaigns to build brand visibility and attract early interest from both renters and vehicle providers.
- Participated in an entrepreneurship development session organised with NEDA (National Enterprise Development Authority), gaining insight into how student ventures can transition into formal businesses.

October 2026

- Began direct B2B outreach by calling car rental companies across our target areas, pitching the benefits of listing their fleets on Yamu Car Rentals and guiding interested owners through account registration and vehicle onboarding.
- Represented our startup at Skill Expo 2026, where we exhibited the live Yamu Car Rentals platform, pitched our value proposition to industry visitors, educators, and students, and gathered direct user feedback.
- Refined the platform based on early company and expo feedback, including simplifying the Rental Company Dashboard by removing legacy inquiry/bid tabs so fleet managers can focus cleanly on Fleet, Bookings, and Company Profile settings.

2. Description of any internal/external training undertaken ***

LeapGen Monthly Progress Meetings (Internal)

- Participated in formal monthly review sessions with Dr. Dinesh Arunathileka and the LeapGen mentoring panel. Each session evaluated individual team member contributions, milestone completion, technical and commercial shortcomings, and next-step priorities. The constructive critique received in these reviews directly drove our pivot from a high-risk peer-to-peer car sharing concept to a centralised rental company marketplace.

LeapGen Weekly Sessions & Workshops (Internal)

- Attended weekly accelerator sessions hosted by the LeapGen team covering startup fundamentals, customer discovery, lean validation, and pitch preparation. These weekly gatherings also connected us to external exhibition opportunities and guided how we structured our marketing for both Desert Club and Yamu Car Rentals.

August 2026

- LeapGen Workshop on Marketing Strategies (Internal): Focused on digital positioning, customer acquisition channels, social media storytelling, and low-budget startup promotion. We directly applied these techniques when planning our September social media rollout for Yamu Car Rentals.

September 2026

- NEDA Entrepreneurship Development Programme (External): Attended a specialized session conducted by the National Enterprise Development Authority (NEDA), a government body supporting SMEs and startups in Sri Lanka. The session covered business registration pathways, institutional support schemes, and how student founders can scale from university incubation into sustainable commercial enterprises.

October 2026

- Skill Expo 2026 Exhibition & Pitching (External): Participated as an exhibiting startup team, demonstrating the live Yamu Car Rentals web application to public visitors and industry guests. Pitching repeatedly throughout the exhibition sharpened our ability to explain our technical product and business model concisely under real-time questioning.

3. Reflection on your learning (e.g. skills and knowledge gained) from the above

Operating Desert Club across three university campuses taught me interpersonal and commercial skills that classroom projects rarely provide. Approaching strangers, starting conversations, explaining our product, and handling real-time feedback built my confidence in face-to-face communication. Presenting Yamu Car Rentals at LeapGen reviews and Skill Expo 2026 further expanded my professional networking abilities, teaching me how to tailor how I explain our platform depending on whether I am speaking to a student customer, a rental company owner, or an academic supervisor.

From a business operations standpoint, the six-week pudding cart demonstrated how unit economics, supply chain reliability, and pricing work in practice. Experimenting with recipes at home, securing permission to trade in front of a temple near the University of Sri Jayewardenepura, and adjusting our unit price from Rs. 200/- to Rs. 250/- after the first week showed me how small operational decisions

directly affect sustainability. Equally important, pivoting Yamu Car Rentals away from private household cars to verified rental companies taught me that a good startup idea must account for legal, insurance, and trust realities—not just software features.

Technically, serving as the full-stack developer for Yamu Car Rentals significantly deepened my software engineering capabilities. Designing the MongoDB schemas (Users, Companies, Vehicles, Rentals, Bookings, and Reviews), building Express REST endpoints, and creating a responsive React frontend taught me how data flows across a production web application. Deploying the app and fixing live bugs — such as multi-condition MongoDB queries for company fleet rentals, role-based authorization checks, and mobile layout constraints—showed me the difference between code that merely runs locally and software that is reliable and secure for real users.

4. Identify any areas requiring improvement (if any)

- Customer Discovery & Empathy: I need to improve how I uncover what customers and rental company owners truly feel and need during interviews, rather than relying on our team's internal assumptions when prioritising features.
- Market & Competitor Analysis: I need to sharpen my ability to analyse the local mobility and rental market systematically so we can identify service gaps and market loopholes that existing directories and classified sites fail to solve.
- B2B Sales & Persuasion: Cold-calling rental companies in October showed me that convincing traditional business owners to adopt a new digital platform requires stronger objection handling and clearer demonstration of return on investment.
- Time Management Across Parallel Commitments: Balancing physical cart operations, full-stack coding, bug fixing, and cold outreach simultaneously highlighted the need for stricter sprint planning and task estimation.

5. Your goals or targets for the next couple of months based on areas requiring improvement (if any)

- Advance Technical Proficiency in Modern Web & Cloud Technologies: Deepen my skills in automated testing, performance optimisation, cloud deployment pipelines, and security hardening so Yamu Car Rentals can scale reliably as traffic grows.
- Stay Current with Emerging Industry Trends: Continuously track developments in modern JavaScript frameworks, database indexing, and AI-assisted search/recommendation tools that could improve how customers match with rental vehicles.
- Establish Structured User Feedback Loops: Conduct regular follow-ups with onboarded rental companies and early renters over the next two months to measure satisfaction and guide our product roadmap.
- Expand Fleet Onboarding: Increase the number of verified rental companies and active vehicles listed on Yamu Car Rentals across key university and urban hubs.
- Map Long-Term Startup & Career Pathways: Work with LeapGen mentors and NEDA contacts to evaluate post-incubation options, including seed funding, formal company registration, and long-term career paths in software engineering and tech entrepreneurship.

6. Describe and evaluate your own skills in relation to the graduate attributes and the professional skills needed in the sector

My placement experience with LeapGen, combining the Desert Club micro-business and the full-stack

development of Yamu Car Rentals, has directly developed the core graduate attributes and professional competencies required in the computing industry:

Technical & Software Engineering Competence: Designing, coding, deploying, and debugging a production MERN-stack web application end-to-end demonstrated my ability to translate business requirements into working software. While my core full-stack implementation skills are strong, I am actively working to strengthen my expertise in automated testing and scalable cloud infrastructure.

Critical Thinking & Problem Solving: Diagnosing production bugs (such as complex ownership vs. company queries in MongoDB and authentication edge cases) and critically evaluating our initial peer-to-peer business model required structured root-cause analysis and objective decision-making.

Teamwork & Collaborative Leadership: Operating as a four-person founding team required clear division of labour across cooking, stall operations, UI/UX design, software development, and outreach. Relying on my co-founders during the multi-campus cart expansion strengthened my collaborative and leadership skills.

Communication & Stakeholder Engagement: Daily customer interactions at the pudding cart, formal monthly progress presentations to LeapGen supervisors, public pitching at Skill Expo 2026, and cold outreach calls to rental agencies have markedly improved my verbal and professional communication.

Commercial Awareness & Entrepreneurial Mindset: Taking two concepts from blank-page brainstorming to real-world execution taught me resilience, resourcefulness (such as sourcing an in-team cook and home kitchen), and commercial awareness.

Ethical & Professional Responsibility: Pivoting away from an uninsured peer-to-peer vehicle model and patching authorization vulnerabilities in our API reinforced my commitment to user safety, data integrity, and responsible software design.

Adaptability & Lifelong Learning: Rapidly learning deployment workflows, mobile-first CSS patterns, and B2B sales techniques during this placement confirmed my ability to adapt quickly to unfamiliar technical and business challenges.

*** it is advisable to present your answers for questions 1 and 2 in chronological order e.g. per month.

Once you have addressed the points (outlined in questions 1-5), ask your supervisor to assess your performance for the month using the following table.

	Below expectation	*Satisfactory*	*Above expectation*	*Outstanding*	*N/A*
Attitude to work					
Quality of work					
Productivity					
Literacy and Communication skills					
Critical Thinking skills					
Reliability					
Global Outlook					
Suitability of future goals *(refer to question 5)*					
Overall Achievement					

Workplace Supervisor Signature: .....

Date: .....

Student Name & Signature: .....

Date: .....

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